



**SHANTIES ON MUMBAI
AIRPORT LAND**

The state keeps making new **LEGISLATION ON SLUMS** but lacks the will to act on the laws.

while civic amenities continue to shrink in comparison. By continuously extending the regularisation deadline, the state Government is legalising illegal squatting on government and private land, in a city where property prices are sky-high due to lack of space. Rather than freeing up these lands and providing low cost housing to slum dwellers in other places, politicians are fighting to keep their votebanks in their existing locations. Says Kripashankar Singh, president of the Mumbai Congress: "This decision has been taken on humanitarian grounds. Even slum dwellers have a right to a better life. But yes, political parties should work together to prevent more slums from coming up. The state and Central Government authorities and municipal corporation should work towards protecting their land from squatters."

In order to appease its votebank of 60 lakh people, the Government is speeding to regularise squatters who have constructed their shanties before January 1, 2000, by giving them title rights to the land so that they can come together and redevelop the land with a builder. It's win-win for the

squatters and developers who get thrice the floor space index on that land. The Government obviously is happy to capture a votebank at the cost of its own land. Sarang Wadhawan, managing director of Housing Development and Infrastructure Ltd (HDIL), says: "The core problem of high real estate prices in Mumbai stems because there is a cap on the development potential of land, which the Government needs to relax as there isn't enough land. This will help prices of land come down. And in turn this will make affordable housing a reality."

Take for instance, the Mumbai International Airport (MIAL), which has only 1,850 acres available to it for airport development activities. Of this, 272 acres are under slums which the Government has never bothered to remove. After handing over the airport to GVK, the Government facilitated the clearance of the slums from airport land. The bid to clear the slums from airport land has been won by HDIL, under which the company will relocate

85,000 families to different parts of the city where the company will develop tenements for free. In return, the company gets to build three times more than it originally would to compensate for the free tenements it will hand over and it will get to exploit 100 acres of the airport land for commercial purposes for which it will get the land on a long lease.

Ironically, the state Government keeps coming up with new legislation on slums but lacks the will to act on it. In 2002, the Government amended the Slum Rehabilitation Act to make squatting and illegal construction a punishable offence. Still new shanties keep springing up in new areas. Over 500 new families come into the city every single day and illegal structures keep coming up but no slum lord has been brought to book. A few weeks ago a fire destroyed slums in Behrampada and Gharibnagar area of Bandra East, but the very next week the slum dwellers built new shanties under the new sky walk. Rather than protect public spaces from encroachments, the Government, it seems, is only too desperate to convert Mumbai into one big slum. ■